

A Metta & Tonglen Workbook

An invitation into two of the most powerful heart-practices in the Buddhist tradition: Metta (loving-kindness) and Tonglen (taking and sending). Together, they form a complete arc of compassionate attention: first, learning to radiate warmth outward in ever-widening circles, then learning to receive suffering with an open hand and transform it through the spaciousness of awareness itself.

The heart does not need to be forced open; it needs only to be reminded of what it already knows. Read slowly, pause often, and let the practices settle into your body before moving on. There is no hurry. The practices deepen over a lifetime.

PART ONE

Metta

The practice of loving-kindness: phrases, stages, and the felt sense of a heart that radiates warmth outward.

PART TWO

Tonglen

Taking and sending: breathing in suffering and breathing out relief, grounded in the openness of awareness itself.

ORIENTATION
BEFORE YOU BEGIN

How to Use This Workbook

This workbook is organised as a living practice sequence rather than a book to be read straight through once. Move through it from beginning to end across a single retreat day, or return to individual sections again and again over weeks and months. Each section contains instruction, reflection prompts, and suggested sitting times. There is no hurry. These practices deepen over a lifetime, and the workbook is built to be lived with rather than finished.

01. Orient Yourself

Read the introductory material for each practice before sitting. Understand the structure before you begin.

02. Sit with the Practice

Each section includes a guided sitting suggestion. Allow 20 to 45 minutes for full immersion, or adapt to your time.

03. Reflect and Write

Journaling prompts follow each main practice. Writing anchors insight in the body and makes it teachable.

04. Return and Repeat

Return to the same stage for several sessions before moving forward. Depth matters more than progress.

A NOTE BEFORE YOU BEGIN

These practices are powerful. If strong emotion arises, rest in breath awareness, soften your body, and return gently. You are allowed to take care of yourself as you practice caring for others.

Metta and Tonglen belong to the same family of heart-cultivation, though they move in different directions. Metta radiates outward: from a settled place of warmth, it sends care in ever-widening circles, beginning with yourself and ending with all beings everywhere. Tonglen moves toward what is difficult directly: it receives suffering on the inhale and returns ease on the exhale, trusting that awareness itself is spacious enough to hold what arises without being harmed by it.

Whether you are sitting with these practices for the first time or returning to them after years of familiarity, may you find here both clear instruction and genuine warmth. The heart does not need to be forced open. It needs only to be reminded of what it already knows.

PART ONE · METTA CHAPTER ONE

The Practice of Loving-Kindness

"Just as a mother would protect her only child with her own life, even so let one cultivate a boundless love towards all beings.": The Metta Sutta

Metta is the Pali word often translated as loving-kindness, though it carries undertones of friendship, goodwill, and the simple wish for others to be well. Unlike romantic love or conditional affection, Metta is a deliberate orientation of the heart, a turning toward, a wishing well. It does not depend on whether we feel like it. It does not require the object of our love to be lovable on any given morning.

In practice, we cultivate Metta by directing phrases of well-wishing, gently and repeatedly, like water wearing stone, toward ourselves and outward in expanding circles. Over time, what begins as a somewhat effortful mental exercise becomes something far more organic: a resting quality of the heart, a default warmth that begins to colour ordinary moments. We must first water the soil of our own inner garden before we can genuinely nourish anyone else.

The Phrases of Metta are the vehicle of the practice: simple, sincere wishes that we repeat, either silently or aloud, directing them toward ourselves and others. The traditional phrases vary across lineages, but what matters most is that they feel genuine and alive in your particular body and heart. Below are the core phrases we use, offered as a starting template. You are warmly encouraged to find your own phrasing as the practice deepens.

May you be happy

A broad, open wish for joy and ease: a deeper settledness of being, beyond the fleeting happiness of circumstances.

May you be healthy

Wishing vitality and physical ease. When illness is present, this becomes especially tender: health held with tenderness, honouring what is rather than demanding what should be.

May you be at rest

Deeper than peace: a releasing of all striving. The ease of a creature that has come home.

May you be nourished

Wishing fullness at every level: body, mind, relationship, spirit. May nothing essential be lacking.

May you be peaceful

May your inner weather settle. May anxiety, restlessness, and agitation find rest. May you know stillness.

May you be free

Free from pain, from difficult emotions, from what binds the heart. Ultimately: may you be liberated.

Repeat these phrases slowly, with genuine intention. Let them land. If the mind wanders, and it will, gently return. The wandering is not failure. The returning is the practice.

The traditional Metta practice moves outward in concentric circles of care, beginning with oneself and gradually expanding to encompass all sentient life. This movement follows the natural geometry of compassion. We begin where we are. We cannot genuinely wish others well if we have bypassed ourselves. Each stage is a doorway; none is more important than another.

- ① **Self**
The seat of all compassion.
- ② **A Loved One**
Someone easy to love.
- ③ **A Neutral Person**
Someone we barely know.
- ④ **A Difficult Person**
Someone who challenges us.
- ⑤ **All Beings**
All humans, then all sentient beings.
- ⑥ **Ancestors and All Beings Everywhere**
Past, present, and future.

PACING

Each stage typically receives five to ten minutes of sustained attention in a full sitting. In shorter sessions, choose one or two stages as your focus. The stages are meant to be felt, not rushed through.

PART ONE · METTA

CHAPTER TWO

Stage One: Metta for Self

This is the place of beginning, and for many practitioners, the most difficult stage of all. We live in cultures that have taught us to earn our worth, to help others before we help ourselves, to be suspicious of self-compassion as a form of indulgence. The practice asks us to set that story gently aside.

Settle into your seat. Feel the weight of your body. Breathe naturally. Then, slowly, begin to direct the phrases of Metta toward yourself as you actually are right now, in this particular moment, with your history and your tenderness and your unfinished edges, rather than toward some perfected version of yourself. Let the phrases arrive with sincerity rather than performance.

May I be happy. May I be nourished. May I be healthy. May I be peaceful. May I be at rest. May I be free.

If emotion arises, sadness, resistance, a surprising sweetness, let it be there. If the words feel hollow at first, that is entirely normal. We are planting a seed and trusting that the ground of the heart knows how to receive it. Stay with yourself for several minutes, breathing, wishing, softening.

Reflection Prompt

After your sitting, write for five to ten minutes. What does it feel like to genuinely wish myself well? Where in my body do I feel resistance? Where do I feel openness?

Suggested Sitting

Ten to fifteen minutes. Sit comfortably. Begin with three grounding breaths. Offer the phrases slowly and with care. There is nowhere else to be.

PART ONE · METTA

CHAPTER THREE

A Loved One and a Neutral Person

Having watered the soil of your own heart, you now bring to mind someone you love easily and without complication: a close friend, a child, a beloved teacher, even a cherished animal companion. The key quality here is ease. This is someone whose wellbeing you naturally wish for, someone whose happiness brings you genuine delight. We begin here because Metta flows most freely with them, and we want to feel what the current of loving-kindness actually feels like in the body before extending it to more challenging terrain.

Visualise this person clearly: their face, their smile, a particular memory of them in a moment of ease. Let warmth arise naturally as you hold them in mind. Then begin to direct the phrases of Metta toward them, slowly, as if each phrase were a gentle hand resting on their shoulder.

May you be happy. May you be nourished. May you be healthy. May you be peaceful. May you be at rest. May you be free.

Notice the quality of warmth in your chest or belly. This is the felt sense of Metta. As you practise with this person, you may also expand to include those they love, their family, their community, feeling the circle of care widen naturally. Spend several minutes here, letting the warmth build and circulate through you.

VARYING THE PHRASES

You can vary the phrases here: “May you know joy in each moment. May your days be filled with ease. May nothing essential be lacking.” Let the language stay alive and personal.

A Neutral Person is often the most quietly challenging stage, and the most instructive. A neutral person is someone we encounter regularly but toward whom we hold no particular charge: a cashier at the grocery store, a neighbour we barely know, someone we pass on the street each morning without a second thought. We neither love them nor find them difficult. They exist at the edges of our awareness, unnamed.

And yet they, too, have a life as vivid and as tender as our own. They, too, wake in the night with worries. They, too, carry a history of love and loss. This stage invites us to dissolve the habit of inner indifference, to recognise that our unconscious hierarchy of care, in which some lives register and others do not, is a kind of poverty of the heart. Metta, practised with a neutral person, is an act of deliberate recognition: you are real. Your suffering matters. You are not invisible to me.

May you be happy. May you be nourished. May you be healthy. May you be peaceful. May you be at rest. May you be free.

Simply hold this unnamed, ordinary person in mind and offer them the same care you offered yourself and your beloved. Notice any flatness or lack of resonance; that flatness is itself the material of the practice. Stay, and offer anyway. The phrases are seeds, not performances.

PART ONE • METTA

CHAPTER FOUR

Stage Four: A Difficult Person

We arrive now at what the tradition sometimes calls the enemy, though we prefer the gentler phrase: a difficult person. This is someone who has hurt you, frustrated you, or with whom you are in genuine conflict. It may be a family member, a colleague, a public figure whose actions cause harm. The invitation is to practise the radical act of wishing them well anyway, acknowledging the difficulty fully and without collapsing your legitimate boundaries or bypassing your own pain.

This stage can bring up strong resistance, and that resistance is completely appropriate. Do not force it. Instead, begin with a softer approach: first, acknowledge your own difficulty, offer yourself a round of Metta for the pain this person has caused. Then, very gently, see if you can bring them to mind and offer, perhaps tentatively, a single phrase: may you be free of the causes of your harmful actions, may you know peace. Even a small crack in the wall of resentment is enough. The practice does not require you to approve of what they have done. It asks only that you recognise their humanity.

A Gentling Practice

If the difficult person feels overwhelming, begin instead with someone only mildly irritating: a stranger who was rude, someone who let you down in a small way. Build the capacity gradually.

Reflection Prompt

After sitting, ask: what happened in my body when I tried to wish this person well? What does resentment feel like physically? What, if anything, softened?

PART ONE • METTA

CHAPTER FIVE

All Beings and the Ancestors

We now expand the circle of Metta to encompass all human beings alive on the planet in this very moment: the seven-plus billion souls currently drawing breath, moving through their days, navigating joy and grief and everything in between. This is a vast gesture of the heart, and at first it may feel abstract. That is natural. Allow it to be both conceptual and felt: let images arise, faces, bodies, cities, fields, oceans, and let the warmth of your practice flow through them like light through a window.

We often work with two complementary expansions within this stage. First, we direct Metta to all women, honouring the particular forms of tenderness and strength, suffering and resilience, that women carry. Then to all men, with equal care and without idealisation. The gesture is one of recognition, a seeing of each group as fully human, as deserving of care. From there, we open to all human beings without distinction: every nationality, every generation, every circumstance.

May all human beings alive right now be happy. May all beings be nourished. May all beings be healthy. May all beings be at peace. May all beings be free.

Sit with this for several minutes. Let the phrases radiate outward from the centre of your chest like warmth from a hearth. You do not need to visualise every person individually. Simply trust that the intention carries, the way a radio signal carries even when you cannot see the airwaves moving.

From all human beings, we continue to expand. The great gift of the Buddhist framing of Metta is its radical inclusivity: the circle of compassion does not stop at the border of the human. We extend our well-wishing now to animals, the creatures of land, sea, and sky, the insects, the mammals, the birds, the beings who share this planet and who suffer and seek ease just as we do. Let your heart hold them without hierarchy. A cow in a field. A whale in the deep ocean. A spider in the corner of a room.

Then we move further still, into time itself. We bring to mind our ancestors: those who came before us, known and unknown, who carried their own sorrows and loves across the generations. We offer them Metta across time. And finally, we open to all beings everywhere, in this realm and in realms we cannot see, in the past, the present, and all futures, in the ten directions, as the tradition says. The heart, it turns out, has no ceiling.

All Animals

Every creature that breathes, that seeks food and safety, that knows the warmth of the sun. May they all be free from suffering.

The Ancestors

Those who came before us across the long river of time. May they rest in peace, may their sorrows be transformed, may their love continue forward.

All Beings, Everywhere

In the ten directions, across all realms and times. May all beings without exception be happy, healthy, and free.

Generating Heart Energy and Resting in the Heart Space

Beyond the formal phrases, Metta practice also invites us into a more somatic, energetic dimension: the actual felt experience of generating warmth in the body and consciously radiating it outward. This is less cognitive than the phrase-work and more akin to a kind of inner weather-making. It draws on the body's capacity to produce and channel what we might call heart energy, a warmth that is palpable, directional, and real.

Begin by placing a hand on your chest. Breathe slowly and deeply. With each inhale, imagine warmth gathering in the centre of your chest, invited rather than forced, the way sunlight collects in a warm stone. With each exhale, let that warmth radiate outward: first filling your own body, then extending beyond your skin into the space around you, then outward to fill the room, the building, the neighbourhood, the city, the world. You are tuning a frequency that is already present, not manufacturing something from nothing. Loving-kindness is remembered, not invented.

The Heart Space

Rest your attention in the centre of your chest. Notice any warmth, pressure, or openness. This is your starting point. Let it be exactly as it is.

Gathering Warmth

With each breath, feel warmth collecting at the heart. No effort, simply receive. The heart knows how to generate what is needed.

Radiating Outward

On each exhale, let the warmth expand: body, room, city, world. Trust the signal even when you cannot feel the edges of its reach.

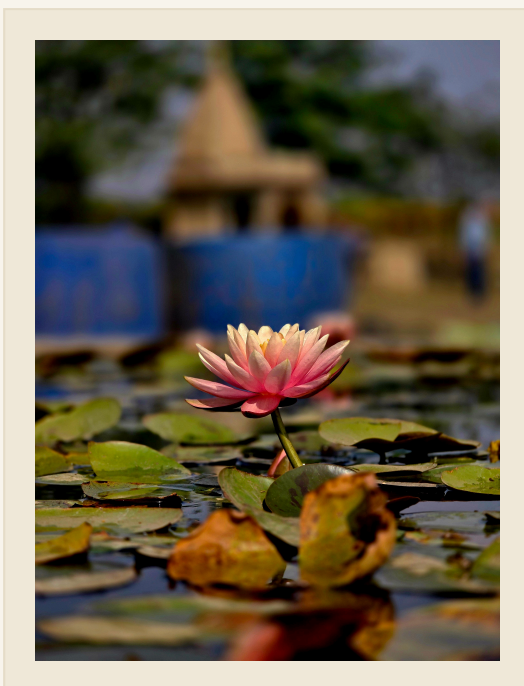
This energetic practice pairs beautifully with the Metta phrases. Use them together, alternating between the words and the felt sense of radiation, letting each deepen the other. Many practitioners find that after some time with the phrases, dropping into this wordless warmth feels like coming home to the essence of what the practice is pointing toward.

One of the most intimate and rewarding dimensions of advanced Metta practice is resting in the heart space: a turning of awareness toward the felt experience of the heart itself as a living, somatic reality, not merely a metaphor. The heart-centre, the anahata in yogic anatomy, the seat of compassion in many Buddhist teachings, is a living place in the body where awareness can genuinely rest, and where something subtle and nourishing can be directly experienced.

After a period of phrase-work and energy-radiation, allow the formal practice to soften. Let the phrases fall away. Simply turn your attention inward and downward, into the chest. What do you notice? There may be warmth, or spaciousness, or a gentle aliveness. There may be grief or longing, equally valid. There may be a quality of stillness that feels like a lake on a windless morning. Whatever is present, simply rest in what is already here, without trying to manufacture a spiritual experience.

The heart is not a room you build; it is a room you discover. Every time you return to it, it is larger than you remembered.

Teachers sometimes describe the heart space as having a quality of natural compassion, as if the heart, left to its own devices, without the overlay of habitual thinking and defensive patterning, naturally wishes well. This resting practice is an opportunity to experience that truth directly, as immediate, felt recognition rather than mere belief. Allow five to ten minutes of simply being here, at home in the heart.



The heart-centre, anahata, held in stillness: the seat from which both Metta and Tonglen are said to arise.

PART TWO • TONGLEN

CHAPTER SEVEN

Taking and Sending

Tonglen is a Tibetan term meaning taking and sending. It is one of the most radical and transformative practices in the Mahayana Buddhist tradition, and one of the most counterintuitive: rather than breathing in beauty and exhaling what is difficult, as many Western meditation techniques suggest, Tonglen reverses this. We deliberately breathe in suffering and breathe out relief, care, and ease. Tonglen is a practice of liberation through openness, grounded in a profound teaching: the heart is spacious enough to hold what arises, and nothing, no pain, no darkness, can destroy the fundamental openness of awareness itself.

As you come to Tonglen, bring patience and curiosity. The practice may feel strange at first, even alarming. The instruction to breathe in suffering can trigger the nervous system's protective responses. Move gently. Know that you are always in charge of the pace. When Tonglen is properly understood, it becomes a relief. We stop fighting reality and begin to meet it with an open hand.

Tonglen practice follows a clear, sequential structure that grounds the practitioner at each stage before moving to the next. Each stage builds on the one before it, moving from an initial awakening of compassion, through direct sensory engagement with suffering, into personal practice, and finally into expansive universal care. The full sequence takes twenty to forty minutes in a dedicated sitting, though individual stages can also be practised on their own.

- ① **Flash of Bodhichitta**
Touching the root of compassion that is already present.
- ② **Texture**
Feeling the specific quality of a particular suffering.
- ③ **A Particular Person**
Breathing in their suffering, breathing out relief.
- ④ **All Beings**
Expanding the same movement to everyone who suffers this way.

THE FULL ARC

These four stages form a complete arc, from the opening of the heart, through the embodied encounter with suffering, to the vast, impersonal compassion that characterises bodhichitta in its fullest expression. Practise each stage fully before moving to the next. Over time, the movement between stages becomes fluid, almost natural, like a song you have learned by heart.

PART TWO · TONGLLEN

CHAPTER EIGHT

Stage One: Flash of Bodhichitta

Bodhichitta, often translated as awakening mind or enlightened heart, is the root from which Tonglen grows. Before we enter the practice proper, we pause to touch this root. A flash of bodhichitta is a moment of genuine recognition, brief and clear, an experience of the compassionate heart already present beneath our habitual layers of self-protection and distraction, rather than a sustained state of enlightenment.

To access this flash, we might begin with a simple question, held gently and without effort: what do I truly care about? What, in my deepest self, do I wish for all beings? We are not looking for a grand answer. We are listening for something small and true: a flicker of care, a warmth that arises unbidden, a memory of being held or of holding another in a moment of genuine compassion. This is enough. This flicker is the seed of bodhichitta.

Sit quietly for two to three minutes before beginning the formal practice. Breathe naturally. Let the question rest in you. When you notice even the smallest pulse of genuine care, for yourself, for someone you love, for a stranger you glimpsed in pain, that is your doorway. Rest there briefly, acknowledge it, and allow it to be the ground on which you stand as you enter the practice. The practice is simply noticing the compassion that is already there.

IF NOTHING ARISES

Simply recall a moment in your life when you genuinely wished someone relief from suffering. That memory is your anchor. It is always enough.

PART TWO · TONGLLEN
CHAPTER NINE

Stage Two: Texture

The second stage of Tonglen is one of its most distinctive and powerful elements. Rather than working immediately with a specific person or universal suffering in the abstract, we pause to feel the texture of a particular kind of suffering, to sense its specific quality in the body and mind before we attempt to breathe it in. This is what makes Tonglen intimate and real rather than conceptual.

Choose a difficult subject that you feel personally affected by: something that genuinely resonates, not something overwhelming. It might be addiction, grief, the particular texture of loneliness, the helplessness of watching someone you love suffer, the weight of shame, the numbness of depression, the agitation of anxiety. Or it might be more general: the texture of suffering itself, as a fact of sentient existence. Whatever you choose, spend a moment actually feeling into it, letting your body know what this particular thing feels like. Where does it live? Is it heavy or sharp? Cold or hot? Constricted or hollow?

Addiction

The pull, the shame cycle, the desperate seeking.

Grief

The specific weight of loss, the absence that has a shape.

Loneliness

The particular ache of being unseen, unmet.

Anxiety

The tightness, the future-pulling, the body on alert.

General Suffering

The simple, universal weight of being a sensitive being in an uncertain world.

You do not need to wallow in this texture. You only need to genuinely recognise it. Two or three breaths of true recognition is enough to make the subsequent stages deeply real rather than merely performed. This stage transforms Tonglen from a conceptual exercise into a practice of the body.

PART TWO · TONGLLEN
CHAPTER TEN

Stage Three: A Particular Person

Now, holding that texture of suffering in your awareness, bring to mind a particular person, someone who you know is experiencing exactly this kind of suffering, or someone who comes to mind when you think about it. This person does not need to be someone you know personally. They may be a stranger you heard about, a composite figure, or simply anyone who is suffering in this way right now. What matters is that they feel real to you, a genuine, breathing being whose pain you can recognise.

Visualise this person as clearly and kindly as you can. Then, deliberately and with care, begin the core movement of Tonglen: breathe in their particular suffering, the thick, dark, or heavy quality of whatever they are carrying, and breathe out some form of relief. The relief does not need to be the exact opposite of the pain. It might be warmth, spaciousness, a sense of being held, ease, lightness, or simply the feeling of not being alone. Let your instinct guide you.

On the inhale, their pain, dark and heavy, comes toward you. On the exhale, something gentle, bright, or easeful moves toward them. As the suffering arrives, it dissolves completely in the vast emptiness of the Self; it leaves no trace. You breathe out from the bodhichitta place.

This is the heart of the teaching: the suffering does not accumulate in you. It arrives and evaporates completely in the spaciousness of awareness, the way a cloud dissolves in the open sky. You cannot be harmed by breathing in another's suffering in this practice, because the practice is rooted in the recognition that your true nature, awareness itself, is larger than any suffering that passes through it. Stay with this person for five to seven breaths, or as long as feels genuine and alive.

PART TWO · TONGLEN

CHAPTER ELEVEN

Stage Four: All Beings

From this one particular person, you now expand the practice outward, first to all beings who suffer in this particular way. If you have been working with addiction, you now bring to mind all beings everywhere who are caught in the grip of addiction right now, their craving, their shame, their hunger for relief. You breathe in the collective texture of their suffering and breathe out collective ease. Let the scale of the gesture be vast, but grounded in the same genuine compassion you felt for the one person.

From there, you may expand further: to all beings experiencing any form of suffering, in any realm, in this moment. The inhale draws in the full weight of suffering everywhere; the exhale sends out compassion, relief, care, and ease in all directions. And still, this vast inflow of suffering dissolves completely the moment it arrives. The heart is not a container that fills and overflows. It is an open sky. Every cloud that enters it simply vanishes. You breathe out again from the clear, undiminished place of bodhichitta.

Breathe In

The suffering of all beings, dark, heavy, real, drawn in with full awareness and willingness.

Dissolves Completely

In the vast emptiness of the Self, the suffering evaporates, leaving no trace, causing no harm.

Breathe Out

From the bodhichitta place: warmth, ease, compassion, relief, sent outward to all beings without exception.

Return to Ground

The heart, spacious and unharmed, returns to its natural openness. The cycle begins again.

One of the most common hesitations that practitioners bring to Tonglen is this: won't breathing in suffering harm me? Won't it leave residue? Won't I absorb what I am taking in? This is a wise and understandable concern, and it deserves a direct answer. The practice is safe. That safety does not come from clever reasoning; it comes from a direct insight about the nature of awareness itself.

The teaching is this: the suffering you breathe in during Tonglen does not accumulate in you because it encounters something larger than itself, the open, spacious quality of awareness, sometimes called emptiness or shunyata. This emptiness is the quality of awareness that is always already present, beneath our thoughts and reactions, before our stories about ourselves and others, spacious rather than vacant. When suffering arrives in this space, it is like a flame touched to water; it simply goes out. There is nothing for it to burn, no solid self to wound.

This is why, in Tonglen, we always begin from bodhichitta, the awakened, compassionate heart, rather than from our ordinary ego-self. The ordinary self might indeed be harmed by taking on too much. But when we are established, even briefly, in the openness of the bodhichitta place, we are practising from a dimension of ourselves that is genuinely unassailable. The practice gradually trains us to know this dimension more reliably. In time, Tonglen becomes a form of rest, a reminder of who we truly are.

IF IT FEELS LIKE TOO MUCH

If the practice feels overwhelming at any point, return to your own breath and your own body. Offer yourself Metta. The most important thing is to practise from genuine capacity, not from spiritual ambition.



Prayer flags carry blessing on the wind, a fitting image for Tonglen's outward-moving breath of compassion.

INTEGRATION

CHAPTER TWELVE

Weaving Metta and Tonglen Together

While Metta and Tonglen are distinct practices with their own structures and emphases, they belong to the same family of heart-cultivation and complement each other beautifully. Metta moves outward: from a place of warmth, it sends care. Tonglen moves inward and outward simultaneously: it receives what is difficult and returns what is healing. Together, they train the full breath of compassion: the willingness to be moved by suffering and the capacity to respond with love.

Many practitioners find that alternating between the two practices within a single retreat day creates a particularly rich and balanced experience. A morning sitting of Metta, gentle, radiating, phrase-based, can open the heart and establish warmth. An afternoon session of Tonglen can then deepen that warmth into something more active and relational, moving toward suffering directly rather than merely wishing well from a distance. The two practices create a kind of rhythm, an inhale and exhale of the contemplative life itself.

Metta

Radiates warmth outward. Works with well-wishing, phrases, and the expansion of care through concentric circles. Trains the baseline quality of the heart.

Tonglen

Moves toward suffering directly. Works with the breath, texture, and the transformation of pain through spacious awareness. Trains the active courage of compassion.

Below is a suggested format for a complete sixty-minute sitting that weaves together both practices. Adapt it freely: the times are approximate, and the most important quality is genuine attention, not adherence to a schedule. If a particular stage calls for more time, give it. If the heart is full after a shorter period, that fullness is its own instruction.

TIME	PRACTICE ELEMENT	NOTES
0–5 min	Settling and grounding	Three deep breaths; feel your body; arrive in this moment
5–10 min	Metta: Self	Offer the phrases slowly; feel the heart space
10–15 min	Metta: Loved one and neutral person	Let warmth expand naturally; use phrases and energy-radiation
15–22 min	Metta: Difficult person and all humans	Gentle with the difficult stage; open wide for all humans
22–27 min	Metta: All beings and ancestors	Rest in the vast expansion; allow images to arise freely
27–32 min	Resting in the heart space	Drop phrases; simply be present in the warmth you have generated
32–35 min	Tonglen: Flash of bodhichitta	Touch the root of compassion; let it be small and genuine
35–40 min	Tonglen: Texture	Choose your subject; feel it in the body
40–50 min	Tonglen: Particular person and all beings	Full breathing practice; trust the emptiness
50–60 min	Resting and dedication	Sit quietly; dedicate the merit to all beings

Every traditional Buddhist practice session ends with a dedication of merit: a moment of consciously offering whatever benefit has been generated by the practice outward, to all beings, rather than hoarding it for oneself. The dedication is itself a form of Metta, a final gesture of generosity that completes the arc of the session and affirms the fundamental intention behind everything we have done.

The dedication need not be elaborate. A simple, sincere offering is enough. You might use traditional language, or you might find your own words. What matters is the genuine quality of the intention, the actual turning of the heart toward others as the session closes.

By the merit of this practice, may all beings be happy. May all beings be free from suffering. May all beings know the joy of liberation. May no being be left behind.

INTEGRATION
CHAPTER THIRTEEN

Journaling and Reflection Practice

Writing is one of the most powerful tools available to the contemplative practitioner. Writing anchors insight in language and memory: it complements direct practice rather than replacing it, helping you hear what the practice has produced and track the subtle arc of transformation over time. Keep a dedicated journal for your Metta and Tonglen practice, an honest, private record of what you actually notice rather than a performance of spiritual progress.

The prompts below are offered as gateways, not requirements. Write freely, without editing or self-judgment. Let the writing follow the practice's texture rather than what you think you should be experiencing. The most surprising and useful insights often emerge in the moments when the pen is moving without a plan.

After Metta for Self

What does genuine self-compassion feel like in my body?
Where do I encounter resistance? What happens when I truly wish myself well, even for thirty seconds?

After the Difficult Person Stage

What arose in me? What did resentment feel like physically? Did anything, however small, soften, and if so, what?

After Tonglen Stage Two, Texture

What texture of suffering did I choose, and why this one?
Where do I know this suffering personally? What does it feel like to acknowledge that others carry it too?

After a Complete Session

How do I feel in comparison to how I felt before I sat?
What, if anything, has shifted, in my body, my perspective, my sense of the world?

INTEGRATION
CHAPTER FOURTEEN

Common Challenges and How to Meet Them

Every practitioner encounters difficulty at various points in Metta and Tonglen practice. These difficulties are not signs that the practice is failing. They are the practice. What follows is an honest guide to the most common challenges, offered with the warmth that these practices are meant to cultivate in you.

“The phrases feel hollow.”

This is extremely common, especially at the beginning. Do not try to force feeling. Simply continue offering the phrases with sincerity. The felt sense often arrives after many repetitions, like a key that finally finds its groove. Trust the practice, not the mood.

“Tonglen feels frightening.”

Begin very small: a single breath, a mild discomfort, a gentle intention. The practice scales. You are never required to take on more than you can genuinely hold. Ground in bodhichitta first.

“Nothing seems to be happening.”

The deepest changes in these practices often occur beneath the threshold of felt experience, like roots growing in the dark. Keep sitting. Practitioners who have sat for years report that the changes show up in how you live, not just how you feel on the cushion.

“I feel overwhelmed by the difficult person.”

Step back. Return to yourself and offer yourself a round of Metta first. Then try someone only slightly difficult. Build gradually. There is no spiritual merit in forcing what is not ready.

“My mind wanders constantly.”

This is the nature of mind. The practice is in the returning, not the sustaining. Each return is an act of genuine compassion toward your own wandering heart. Count the returns, not the wanderings.

INTEGRATION
CHAPTER FIFTEEN

Working with Grief in These Practices

Both Metta and Tonglen have a particular relationship with grief. Honoured rather than resisted, grief becomes a doorway that can open the heart in ways that joy alone cannot. Grief is love with nowhere to go. In these practices, it finds a direction: it is transformed into compassion, into the recognition that all beings who have loved have also lost, and that this shared vulnerability is the very ground on which our connection rests.

If grief arises in your practice, for yourself, for someone you have lost, for the state of the world, do not push it away. Invite it to be part of the practice. In Metta, you can offer the phrases specifically to grief itself, or to the part of you that carries grief, or to all beings who are grieving right now. In Tonglen, grief is one of the most potent textures to work with: breathing in the specific weight of loss, breathing out the warmth of being accompanied, of not being alone in your mourning.

Many practitioners report that their most powerful experiences in Metta and Tonglen practice have come through grief, a grief that, rather than contracting the heart, becomes the vehicle through which the heart finally opens fully. Be patient with this. Grief has its own timing. The practice will hold you as you hold it.



A candle offered in remembrance: grief and compassion held together, one of the oldest gestures of the contemplative traditions.

FURTHER READING
BIBLIOGRAPHY

Further Reading and Resources

The teachings in this workbook draw on a rich tradition of practice and scholarship. The following texts are warmly recommended for those who wish to go deeper into either Metta or Tonglen practice. Each represents a slightly different doorway into the same vast house of the heart.

- **Lovingkindness: The Revolutionary Art of Happiness**, Sharon Salzberg. The essential modern text on Metta practice, written by one of the teachers who introduced it to the West. Warm, practical, and deeply personal.
- **The Places That Scare You**, Pema Chödrön. A luminous introduction to Tonglen and bodhichitta, written with characteristic directness and warmth. See also *Start Where You Are* for a workbook-style companion.
- **Training the Mind and Cultivating Loving-Kindness**, Chögyam Trungpa. The classic commentary on the Lojong slogans, the doctrinal basis for Tonglen practice. More technical, but invaluable for the practice's deeper roots.
- **In the Buddha's Words**, Bhikkhu Bodhi. For reading the Metta Sutta and related texts in their original Pali context, with accessible scholarly commentary. The source material for the Theravada Metta tradition.
- **Radical Compassion**, Tara Brach. A contemporary, psychologically informed approach to loving-kindness and self-compassion, integrating mindfulness with attachment theory and somatic awareness.

CLOSING
A CLOSING BLESSING

The Practice Has Barely Begun

You have come to the end of this workbook, and yet the practice, the real practice, has barely begun. Everything here is pointing at something that lives beyond words: the actual experience of an open heart, in actual contact with actual life, meeting what arises with something other than contraction or indifference. This is the life's work. It cannot be completed in a sitting, a course, or a workbook. But it can be begun, again and again, in each breath, in each moment of return.

Metta teaches us to wish well without condition. Tonglen teaches us to move toward suffering without flinching. Together, they are the training of a bodhisattva: a being who has decided, in some quiet and definitive corner of the heart, to remain present for the full spectrum of this extraordinary, painful, luminous existence, and to meet it with love.

May this practice be of benefit to all beings, everywhere, without exception. May every being know that they are not alone. May the heart that has been touched by these words go on to touch others. May we all find our way home.

With deep bows and genuine warmth: may your practice flourish.

